

Brancusi

With his cutting-edge, sleek and simplified works, Constantin Brancusi (1876–1957) introduced abstraction and Primitivism to three-dimensional art. His originality made him internationally renowned, and he was acknowledged as one of the most influential modern sculptors. Growing up in a Romanian village, he tended the land and learned the traditional folk crafts of wood- and stone-carving. But after studying sculpture in Bucharest, Munich and the École des Beaux-Arts in Paris, he saw a Fauvist exhibition, and realized that artists no longer had to try to emulate the world as it appeared.

An admirer of Gauguin's primitive-style wood carvings, he studied with Rodin, but left after two months, claiming that 'nothing can grow under the shadow of a great tree'. After working with Modigliani, from 1907 he began blending all he had learned in a quest to portray spiritual truths. He emphasized pure lines and balance with natural themes, and reduced his elements to create abstracted, serene ovoid forms with curved, smooth contours.



Brancusi, *Mademoiselle Pogany [I]*, 1912